

Chapter 147_2 - Turning Point

An eerie silence appeared in front of Jingshan Palace. The crackling sounds of flames burning overhead were partially blocked by the barrier before reaching Ning Fuyi's ears. Occasionally, a few panicked fairy attendants ran past with their heads covered, hiding in corners.

Ning Fuyi's eyes saw only the barrier, like a pink and white cover separating Cloud Ascension Mountain from the outside world. Going up the steps, hundreds of disciples had already stood solemnly in front of Cloud Deep Hall. Hundreds of gazes fixed tightly on the overhead barrier, with no one speaking.

Even disciples who were usually rather carefree now held their magical artifacts and stood on the mountain peak, protecting Cloud Ascension Mountain beneath their feet.

The fire continued falling in clusters. Wherever it passed, no life remained. The sky above Cloud Ascension Mountain was now a sea of fire - flames without smoke or dust, yet capable of instantly burning away dust and even clouds.

Occasionally, frightened birds would take flight, only to burst into flames the moment they approached the fire, silently turning to light smoke.

Seeing the firelight, the common people at the foot of the mountain all poured out of their homes. The long streets were immediately packed with people. Countless civilians trembled as they embraced their loved ones, while some elderly people knelt on the spot, prostrating endlessly toward the fire-crowned mountain peak.

The people formed a human sea, murmuring prayers for divine protection.

Fortunately, everything happening in the mortal realm had nothing to do with the sun and moon. The sun still rose in the east and set in the west. Perhaps because there were no clouds to obstruct it, this day's sunset clouds were more magnificent and intense than any other day.

The circulation of immortal power around Ning Fuyi could no longer keep up with the speed at which the barrier was disappearing. She felt dizzy several times but silently steadied herself, finally biting her tongue until it bled without even realizing it.

Blood flowed from the corner of her mouth, not discovered by Chu Qingqiu until it reached her chin. Chu Qingqiu paled and said in a trembling voice: "Ning Fuyi..."

"I won't stop you from extinguishing the fire, but if I can block this damned ghost fire and delay it by one day, then you can't die for one day," Ning Fuyi said.

Black robes fell silently at her ankles. Even though her consciousness sea had withered somewhat, she still didn't move an inch.

Chu Qingqiu bit her lip and shed tears. She stared intently at the overhead barrier that had replaced sunlight to illuminate the surroundings, tears continuously dampening her clothes.

Finally, after nightfall descended from all directions, the ghost fire overhead finally stopped falling. Only those that hadn't been extinguished remained, still clinging to and burning the barrier.

But those could no longer cause any significant impact. Only then did Chu Qingqiu withdraw her immortal power and simultaneously pull Ning Fuyi over, forcibly cutting off her immortal force.

The overhead barrier returned to transparency. Ning Fuyi's legs went weak and she fell directly into Chu Qingqiu's arms, her vision turning black.

She didn't remain unconscious for long and soon opened her eyes again. By this time, she was already surrounded by people, with hands constantly reaching out to pull at her. She heard Liu Wenzhu anxiously calling her name.

She looked up and said something quietly - she couldn't hear it herself, and others couldn't hear it either.

She heard Elder Pingyao's sigh: "She's just too exhausted. Bearing a day's worth of ghost fire - this is to be expected."

"Today it wasn't just Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate - other sects also suffered ghost fire attacks and are similarly trapped. It's just that none were as massive in scale as Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate."

Hong Ying on the side continued the conversation: "Why is Penglai targeting us so specifically? If it weren't for the Divine Venerable and Ning Fuyi being here, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate would probably have been completely annihilated today."

"Who knows?" Elder Pingyao was almost replacing breathing with sighing. "But this time Penglai has completely declared war against the Six Realms."

The people around continued chattering noisily for a few more sentences. Chu Qingqiu never spoke throughout.

Finally, Ning Fuyi felt her body lighten as a pair of gentle arms lifted her horizontally. Under everyone's watchful eyes, Chu Qingqiu turned and walked into Jingshan Palace. The crowd exchanged glances, coughed a few times, and stood up.

Everything in Jingshan Palace was peaceful. The flowers in the corner walls continued blooming heartlessly.

Moonlight fell cleanly on the tree tops. In a trance, it looked like a tree full of pear blossoms had bloomed.

Ning Fuyi's hand kept gripping the ice-woven sleeve. In another moment of haziness, she was already lying on the bed. As the sleeve was about to be withdrawn, she held on tightly.

Finally, the owner of the sleeve had to lean down, cool lips sliding from her forehead to her lips, kissing her for a long while.

Only then did she reach out to pry open her fingers, leaving Ning Fuyi grasping futilely, catching only handfuls of empty air.

"Don't..." the woman in black robes cried like a child, tears rolling from her phoenix eyes, utterly helpless.

She had tried so hard. She had attempted to keep her.

"Chu Qingqiu..." She kept shaking her head. "I don't want..."

Chu Qingqiu's eyes were also full of tears. She knelt by the bed, calmly stroking her hair: "Yiyi, we agreed, didn't we?"

"You saw it too - the people filling the city at the foot of the mountain, the disciples filling the mountain, the flowers, grass, and living beings of the world - each has their own life, each has their own story."

"Either I alone die, or let everyone perish together, including you and me."

Her voice was as gentle as wind. Ning Fuyi gradually stopped struggling. She let go of her hand in a daze, her knuckles hitting the bed frame heavily.

"Sleep for a while?" Chu Qingqiu said. She stood up and wiped away Ning Fuyi's tears bit by bit. Finally, her fingertip slid across her brow, and the woman slowly closed her eyes, entering dreamland.

Even in sleep, her tears didn't stop. Chu Qingqiu watched her quietly for a long while, then stood up and walked outside step by step.

Outside was still chaotic, with disciples constantly running past, shouting about something. No one had the mind to rest.

Chu Qingqiu released Bai Lin¹. Bai Lin looked at her with teary, bell-like big eyes and came forward to nuzzle her. Chu Qingqiu touched behind its ears and pointed toward Ning Fuyi.

"From now on, protect her for me. Do you understand?" Chu Qingqiu said.

Bai Lin drooped its eyebrows and slowly moved toward the bed, turning back three times with each step.

Chu Qingqiu watched the person and beast in the room. Suddenly in a trance, she realized that in her ten thousand years of life, those she could care about in the end were just a precious few.

She lowered her eyes then raised them again, stepping down from the platform. Suddenly someone blocked her path. Looking closely, it was a familiar face.

Chu Qingqiu breathed a sigh of relief and reached up to stroke that person's hair. Just as she was about to say something, shock suddenly surged in her eyes.

The shock didn't last long, because she had already gone limp and was falling backward. That person respectfully reached out to steady her form, slowly placing her on the steps.

Fallen flowers remained on the jade steps. Chu Qingqiu rested beside the fallen flowers, powerlessly falling asleep.

Footnotes:

1. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Literally "White Qilin"; Chu Qingqiu's mystical white beast companion